

January 22, 1999

Dear Dan,

I'm looking forward to seeing you again. I don't yet know everything about Cabrini Connections, T/MC, and Kid's Connection but the reading you sent has given me some grounding and has added to my enthusiasm. (Before I forget, could you please send me a copy of Dayton's *Governance is Governance* and the report *A Collaborative Study of Chicago's Youth Services Programs: A Look at 272 Youth Services Programs in the Community*?) Overall, I'm impressed with your history, commitment, and accomplishment and I'm still marveling at the magnificent products your team has created over the years. The style and writing in the reports also indicate the attraction of their authors to your work; I felt a bit of their pride in being part of documenting the development and crusade of Cabrini Connections. Again, thanks for your feedback to my ideas and for teaching me more about community infrastructure building for volunteerism. I'm gaining much from your experience and drive and I will do my best to fuel your excitement for this work by helping create some valuable new experiences.

Based on our exchange so far, I will briefly propose a few options/interests for our next steps together. As appropriate, we can modify, expand and add to these over a phone conversation or maybe over an Internet conversation. These are fairly broad categories from which we can specify our actions.

1. Infrastructure Research and Development/Expansion: Establish an ongoing evaluation system to understand and improve T/MC's infrastructure development. This would include the what's and how's of T/MC infrastructure building (IB), the effects of IB on existing Chicago volunteer programs, and the effects of IB for creating a snowballing tutor/mentor movement in Chicago that other cities won't be able to resist replicating. One critical aspect of this evaluation system is to identify what works and how to replicate and adapt it to other cities or situations.

This evaluation system would be a hybrid of the community change system we're using in YouthFriends and the T/MC mapping with some adaptations in both. My review of the mentoring literature, my personal experiences, and your publications point to the need for building infrastructure. I have yet to see good examples of this. Similarly, as noted throughout *The Kindness of Strangers*, research for how to develop and sustain infrastructure for volunteerism is rare. YouthFriends and T/MC are great beginnings, but both need improvement. I believe that together we could organize a team for successful infrastructure building tied to continuous learning and improvement.

The details of this need more work together. But there are three key elements of such an evaluation system that I feel are particularly important. First, it will be an ongoing process of understanding and improvement. The Chapin Hall case study of T/MC is an

1998-2004 Tutor/Mentor Connection collaboration with
Steve Roussos, U Kansas PhD student in 1998
1998 correspondence-getting acquainted.

excellent review of how T/MC is organized and its recommendation need follow through. However, to build and sustain infrastructure we need an ongoing evaluation process that starts with our vision and goals and helps us reach them. Not to be too harsh on university research, but its main focus is on understanding (mainly for the researchers) and too often its process is not designed for direct use toward improvement. Our system may include university assistance in implementation, but it's primary engine will be by the organization for infrastructure building. We are not in this for the next few years. Even ten years is not sufficient to begin seeing some fruits. Real success will be creating a system that is sustainable long after we are gone.

Second, the evaluation system will focus on *system-level outcome* and include process measures. Let me explain, and please forgive me if this is unwarranted. By system-level I refer to measures at the organizational level rather than the individual level. Participant satisfactions with T/MC and student grades are examples of individual-level measures. Examples of system-level measures may include the creation and improvement of tutoring/mentoring programs, new policies businesses create to support tutoring and mentoring programs, and products of how T/MC and its partners are changing the conditions of Chicago *to create a sustainable tutoring/mentoring infrastructure that promotes successful development from school to work and beyond for all Chicago youth (from what I've read so far, I see the italicized section as the overall mission)*. Participant satisfaction will be important to measure (it's one of the most common organization/program measure). However, I've also seen (and research reports are full of) much satisfaction and no action, no change. That's why we must focus on system-level measures - to capture what the T/MC system is doing.

Now the difference between system *process* and *outcome* measures is also important. Numbers of people served, number of phone inquiries, or number of people who saw an ad are system *process* measures (they tell us about processes of the system). The number of existing programs, number of new programs, number of new ways of doing business to support tutoring/mentoring are examples of system *outcome* measures (they tell us about the system products). Both process and outcome measures, as are individual- and system-level measures, are needed to understand and improve a system or an organization. However, what's missing most from non-profit organization and system research are system-level outcome measures. The products are not measured. One analogy would be McDonald's measuring numbers entering each store and not measuring the number of Big Macs sold. I'm not sure I've been as clear as possible here but I hope I've made some sense. Note however that this evaluation vision is for understanding and improving how T/MC functions as an infrastructure builder. A parallel evaluation vision must exist at the individual level, especially for youth outcomes (to be discussed more in opportunity #2).

Third, the evaluation system must directly produce information that is immediately useful for T/MC to improve its current work. Two questions we would regularly ask: "How is this [evaluation/data] improving our work?" "How is this [evaluation/data] useful to our work?" Granted some of data may only be useful as quarterly or semi-annual

T/MC survey
break-out
by grade, hours
neighborhood.

Need
continuity
partners

summaries, but at minimum the system can capture weekly innovation, success stories, and promising practices being applied by programs throughout Chicago, many with the help of T/MC.

The MacArthur Foundation is already sponsoring a similar system with the University of Kansas Work Group and a community development partnership in Bronzville. After a year working together they are seeking additional funding from MacArthur, the Casey Foundation, and the Ford Foundation (please keep this part quiet since I'm not sure how public this information is). I would suggest that we seek funding for the development and application of such a system from similar sources. We may even be able to get some partners from Chapin Hall or other such sources interested in helping out. Similar research in Chicago is being funded jointly by corporate, philanthropic and public sources. The key is matching our interests with theirs.

2. Impact Assessment: Establish a system to help all mentoring/tutoring organizations systematically measure youth and volunteer (possibly parents and others) satisfaction with their tutoring/mentoring experience and *outcomes* potentially related this experience (e.g., goal attainment, job placement, academic achievement, social development outcomes for youth; similar types of outcomes for volunteers).

This presumes that a system is in place to track that volunteers with who, when, how long, and with what activity(ies). This would provide an excellent opportunity to pilot test a credit card type system for tracking youth and adults in volunteering programs. If the credit card system is not feasible we could collect this information with other tools. HCRC could be a useful partner here. Self-reported information from volunteers and youth could, for some sample of participants, be cross-checked with school records of grades or new employers who hire youth. The company that has helped create our Internet data collection system might also be useful. As with any new development, we would start out with the programs that show interest in this and build from there.

Funding here could come from public or private programs. I could see private sources loving the credit card idea, especially if the using the card could lead to purchases and free food or other products and be used as an advertising tool for businesses. Private funders may also gain information on consumer interests and, if we link with credit card companies and banks they may gain information on future and present credit card users, home and business owners, and investors (e.g., stocks, retirement funds, ventures). We might also be able to get pro bono technology and software resources from credit card companies, software companies, and computer engineering training programs or university departments. I believe that once this system is established, especially if it shows promise for gathering information on the same youth and adults longitudinally, more funding would flow, especially as other cities start replicating it.

3. Competency Development for Program Staff: This is an area in which T/MC already is making a great stride. Improvements could come from more targeted and frequent workshops and more "consulting" or technical assistance on an as needed basis for

existing and developing programs. Currently, this is probably where at least half of my time goes in YouthFriends and the central office does this full-time and even that's not enough. The reports you sent mentioned this is a key part of what you do too. This would be one of the central pieces of infrastructure development. "Program staff" would not only include volunteer coordinators but also business, schools, churches and synagogues, and other community organizations that do volunteering activities or provide support for them. Eventually, other groups would be doing conferences similar to T/MC's, but maybe on more focused topics (e.g., a one-day retreat for business managers and volunteer coordinators on how to work best together). The Internet discussions would be an excellent component here. Leadership, evaluation, program development, marketing, strategic planning, and other competencies could be taught. Some folks might link with the internet-based courses we teach at KU or others throughout the country. The key here would be to expand the leadership available to conduct competency development for program staff and to measure/improve competency attainment and application.

4. Volunteer Screening System: One of the strengths that YouthFriends uses to "sell" itself is its strong screening system. It takes about a month for the paper work to go through, but schools love it and most volunteers appreciate knowing they are part of a program that cares about child safety. YouthFriends provides this free for all participating school districts and I believe we are soon hiring a new screening organization that will reduce the cost to about \$20 per screen. This includes checking FBI criminal records and driving records for both Kansas and Missouri. I'm not sure if volunteer screening services are something you are interested in starting, and it probably exists in some form or another. Some programs are probably taking advantage of it or are required to.

What is desperately needed is a quicker more comprehensive volunteer screening method. Volunteers and programs are hesitant to wait one or months for paper work to go through. Volunteers who have been screened for one program should not have to be re-screened for another program if they can show their screening papers. The screening organization should not be paid multiple times for screening the same volunteer as he/she participates in different programs. Schools, volunteer programs, and volunteers would love a one-stop shop for screening. By screening I means the background check and not the one-to-one interview that all volunteer coordinators do in person. Such a company could produce a good income too; some of which could go back to infrastructure development.

Back in November or December, I remember hearing that the National Crime Statistics Organization (or some other federal group) began a service for a 3-minute background check for purchasers of guns. They mentioned that this included a criminal record check. That means that a storeowner could check a customer's record in 3 minutes and then sell them a gun on the spot. Well if it can be done for gun purchasers there is no reason it cannot be done for volunteers. We could probably collaborate with the government and get federal and local funding to develop this company. I don't believe this

(gun) service is available everywhere, but it most likely exists for big cities. We could start it in Chicago and expand nationally.

I'm sure there are more opportunities, not the least being publishing and disseminating (such as the evaluation best practices on the web) what others and we learn (another income source). We could choose to start on one or any combination of them or maybe something else. We could sit down with a MacArthur or Ford Foundation program officer and see if they are interested in investing some "venture capital" in one or more of these ideas.

What I would love is an opportunity to help bring such ideas to life. Your history, commitment, compassion, and system-level thinking and action attract me to you to do such work. I can't match your history of accomplishment in this work, but I would do my all to match your commitment and compassion. My passion (and, in modesty, some unique expertise) lies in applying research to solve important public problems. If this ambition can benefit your work then I think we'll do well together. There are several ways we can start a more formal working relationship. But I want to make sure I do not oblige you. Ideally, the next steps would be to decide on our mutual goals, develop a time and resource plan, and bring others who could help and benefit. We could also work to expand your research and development team at T/MC. My current work leaves me little time for too much extracurricular activity, but depending on our plan I can make time to get something going (e.g., help develop a business plan and grant proposal) and build in more time after I leave Kansas in July. The April/May conference could be a time to recruit others that may want to help us start something.

Naturally, I am also helping the rapidly expanding YouthFriends in similar work and would love to continue. Our YouthFriends contract is up for negotiation in May. Either way, I will probably be serving YouthFriends from a distance once I leave Kansas. There are so many ways YouthFriends and T/MC could learn and benefit from each other. While YouthFriends is working at a system level, its focus is on one "way" (school-based volunteerism through YouthFriends) unlike T/MC which is promoting many "ways." On the other hand, YouthFriends' lessons on creating flexible, thriving school-based programs could be very helpful to Chicago organizations. I believe that to accomplish grand work there cannot be just one way but many – part of our job is to help nurture and flourish the many ways. Equally important and exciting to me is that T/MC is emphasizing the entire cycle of youth development from school to work, possibly beyond. Even more possibilities could open up as we start uncovering the benefits of volunteerism to other age groups.

I better stop for now. Thanks for listening. Looking forward to your thoughts.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Steve", with a stylized, flowing script.